

The background of the cover is a photograph of a hallway. A red prayer rug with intricate white and black patterns is laid out on the floor. To the left, there is a green plant with long, dark leaves. The walls are a neutral color, and a door is visible in the background. The overall lighting is soft and indoor.

ILM

legacy

Islamic Literary Magazine

2025-2026



Islamic Literary Magazine at Yale

LEGACY

"Nun. By the pen and what everyone writes!"

{68:1}

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Letter from the Editors

Dear Reader,

ILM began as a question. It was my first year in college and I had just returned from the Ivy Muslim Conference. The brothers and sisters who performed were overflowing with talent—poets, writers, performers, thinkers—it was just inspirational. Yet, there was no dedicated Muslim publication on our campus. When I asked our group chat why that was, their response was a simple *“Not sure. Why don’t you make one?”*

So we did. What started as an idea between friends slowly became a team. Ramy, my soon-to-be roommate and now my best friend, was there from the beginning. None of us had ever run a magazine before. We learned as we went. With the help of my older brother (say hi to Briken!), we settled on a name: ILM—the Arabic word for “knowledge.” It felt right. It also gave us our unofficial backup name: I Love Muslims.

At a time when Muslim American identity is increasingly scrutinized and politicized, it feels especially urgent that Muslim authors ensure their voice is heard and claim space for their own narratives. Many of our neighbors may not fully understand us. From ignorance can come fear, and from fear, dehumanization. Literature has always been one of the most powerful tools against distortion. Through writing, reflection, and art, we assert something simple yet radical: we are here, we are thoughtful, and we are deeply committed to mercy, justice, and love—values at the heart of our faith.

For our inaugural issue, we chose the theme Legacy. Legacy asks what we inherit, what we preserve, and what we build. It asks how knowledge travels across generations and how identity endures through story. Our hope is that ILM, in some small but meaningful way, contributes to a legacy that celebrates the beauty and intellectual richness of Islamic literature and culture—and strengthens relationships between communities and all who choose to share this Earth as home.

Thank you for reading our first edition. We are honored to share it with you, and we hope these pages invite reflection, pride, and connection.

Who We Are

ILM at Yale is a creative literary magazine run by undergraduate students at Yale University. Grounded in the Arabic concept of ‘ilm—knowledge—our publication seeks to foster an inclusive platform for Muslim voices on campus while creating space for students passionate about Islamic literature and creative writing more broadly.

Focusing on religious themes and the Muslim experience, we welcome submissions across all creative genres. Our collective is committed to respect, inclusivity, and supporting writers in maintaining a constructive and inspiring space for dialogue on campus—using the power of writing to illuminate the richness and diversity of Islamic traditions.



Issue Theme: Legacy

Legacy is more than inheritance. It is what we choose to remember, preserve, and build upon. In Islamic tradition, knowledge, ‘ilm, shows up 105 times in the Qur’an. It is passed from generation to generation, carried not only in books but in memory, practice, and story. Legacy lives through participation. It survives because it is renewed.

For this inaugural issue, we invite reflection on what we have received and what we will leave behind. How does faith shape the stories we tell? How do culture, family, and scholarship shape who we become? What does it mean to carry something forward with care?

This year feels especially significant for our community as we enter a period of transition. Spring 2026 marks the final semester our beloved musalla will serve before the Chaplain’s Office relocates to Connecticut Hall, closing a chapter of more than two decades. As our community grows in new ways, we find ourselves reflecting on what we are leaving behind and what we are building next.

The pieces that follow explore legacy as memory, responsibility, creativity, and hope—honoring the past while imagining what is still to come.



Special Thanks

With special appreciation, the ILM Editorial Team would like to extend a special thank you to everyone involved in making our community become what it is today. Starting in no particular order:

We would like to thank every single one of our contributors for being kind enough to include each of their brilliant works, even the anonymous authors. Thank you Imam Bajwa, “AR” Abdul-Rehman, and Ustadh Elbousty for your steady and guiding mentorship. Thank you Yale University for allowing us the funding and logistical opportunity to operate this magazine. Thank you Hassaan for the generous supply of pieces, even as you were graduating. Thank you Danish as your advice was foundational in our early phase. Thank you Biriuni for your unwavering support of our instagram (which is @ilmyale btw). Thank you Yasmin for intending to come to our events, even when there were times you could not. Thank you Afnan for reviewing our title cover. Thank you Abdelrahman for reviewing our editorial layout. Thank you Sage for reviewing and hyping up our logo. Thank you Nabiha for being our phantom keynote speaker. Thank you Hasfa, who while serving as our FroCo, supported our idea from the very beginning.

And to all the unnamed brothers and sisters who undoubtedly contributed to our final product, thank you too.

Allahumma barik wa jazakAllahu khairan.

<3

To My High school Literary Magazine,
Who Showed Me With Perspective,
How One Could Love To Write

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The opinions expressed by contributors are their own and do not necessarily represent the views of the publisher, editorial staff, or ownership. The publisher assumes no responsibility for statements made by contributors.



Musalla

Adiya Obolu

Within these 4 walls
We say salaams like breath work
Hold our hearts outside of our chest
And beg The Almighty to help us keep breathing
Occupy our brains with essays and exams
But press our minds into red carpet
Because this dunya is the only test that is worth it

Within these 4 walls
I laugh so much I could cry
And I cry so much I burrow my tears into the ground
Only rising to a statement of The Greatest

Allahu Akbar
Within these 4 walls
We love when nobodies watching
Except the only One that matters
We are cracked archives of our ancestors wildest dreams
Muslimat and Muslimeen
And in sha Allah our lineage will be
Muslim

Within my heart
I carry you all with me
Because you remind me that Allah's mercy can come in the form of people
Perhaps our ease is the light of our friends
And the kindness of our teachers
From the musalla to Jannah
I love you for the sake of Allah

Lahm (Meat)

Mashnoor Chowdhury

A piece of flesh
Flutters
Letting out a sound
An echo
Of the ultimate legacy bestowed
A piece of flesh
Palpates
Letting out a sound
A sigh
The greatest peace ever known

For the words that emanate
From this struggling flesh
Are eternal
As they ensnare
And tug
And honor
The souls that will accept them
But they ensnare
And tug
And rip apart
The souls that disdain them

So let this honored flesh move
So that those souls can truly rest

Ahad

Hassaan Qadir

They called him the son of a
black woman,
Fathered by an Arab slave,
Unfree, unfair,
The tribe did not care,

Bilal, may Allah,
be pleased with his name,
Grew up fast,
in sorrow and pain,

Saw things no child,
should ever see,
Trapped in the shadows,
longing to be free.

He watched his mother,
beaten, oppressed,
By the "noble" master,
they all addressed,

Each lash she endured,
each tear she cried,
Was blamed on her,
no one by her side.

The master was noble,
or so they believed,
He perfumed the idols,
and chanted their screed,

Milk from his herd,
he poured with pride,
While his bloodstained hands,
the truth they denied.

The idolater's milk,
washed blood away,
From the beatings he dealt,
each and every day,

Why did the people
Love the slave master?
Call him pure and clean,
When his deeds were obscene?

Bilal would ask,
And the people they answered,
His lineage, his wealth,
The name of his tribe,
Ancestor worship,
had blinded their eyes,

Ancestor worship,
had blinded their eyes,
All just excuses,
All were just lies,
Jahiliya,
had blinded their eyes,

The world was confusing,
Nothing made sense,
Until into this world,
The Quran was sent,

A clear criterion,
Sent in verses and signs,
Down to a Messenger,
Whose heart truly shined,

What Bilal heard,
He instantly loved,
God is the One,
Qul huw allahu ahad,

A simple message,
That rebuked all their lies,
Like the light of the sunrise,
Banishing night,

Ahadun, ahad,
Sweet to recite,
Ahadun, ahad,
Brought tears to the eyes,

Bilal saw the idols,
Standing so tall,
Ahadun ahad,
Will make you fall,

He went to the market,
Where he had been sold,
Ahadun ahad,
is worth more than gold

And he went to his master,
Who hated his race,
Ahadun ahad,
You cannot debase,

The master grew angry,
Fire in his eyes,

"How dare you defy me?
Do you wish to die?"

*Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,*

They chained up Bilal,
Collared him tight,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

Dragged through the dirt,
Till day turned to night.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

They beat him with stones,
Tied him down with their whips,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

Each lash tore his clothes,
Turned to ragged strips.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

The master grew fearful,
His power was thin,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

How could he control
What was not his to win?

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

Bilal was no slave
To any mere man,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

He served only Allah,
In His perfect plan.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

They blindfolded Bilal,
Threw him on the sand,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

Placed boulders on chest,
Demanded he bend.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

But out in the heat,
The desert sunlight,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

He stayed on the faith,
His heart burning bright.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

No water to drink,
And death closing in,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

Bilal stayed strong,
With courage within.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

The Muslims, his brothers,
Tried for his release,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

They wanted to buy him,
And free him in peace.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

An outrageous price
Ten thousand in gold,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,
Abu-Bakr paid,
For his heart was bold.

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

The cruel master laughed,
Thinking he'd won,

Ahadun ahad,
Ahadun ahad,

But Bilal was freed
With faith like the sun.

Allahuakbar, allahuakbar

The more Bilal learned,
The brighter it shone,

Allahuakbar, allahuakbar,

God judges not race,
But deeds of your own.

ashhadu an la ilaha illa llah

He forgives all your sins,
Lifts up the oppressed,

ashhadu an la ilaha illa llah

Guides you in this life,
Grants peace in the next.

*Ashhadu anna Muhammadan
rasulullah*

Pray five times a day,
Purify your wealth,

*Ashhadu anna Muhammadan
rasulullah*

Be kind to each other,
Be strict with yourself,

hayya 'ala s-salah

They honored Bilal,
And fought side-by-side,

hayya 'ala s-salah

Conquering all,
With faith as their guide,

hayya 'ala l-fala

On top of the Kaaba,
Bilal gave athan,

hayya 'ala l-fala

A powerful sign,
Of what they had won,

Allahuakbar, allahuakbar

Peace for the people,
To practice Islam,

la ilaha illa llah

But after the Prophet,
Salallahu-alayhi wa-sallam,
died,

Bilal cried, and cried, and cried,

He tried to make the athan,
But his voice only broke,
Reunion in the afterlife,
Was his only hope

The years passed by,
And Bilal grew old,
And he became a teacher,
For those entering the fold,

They marveled at him,
So learned and wise,
Scars on his back,
But love in his eyes,

“Tell us, Bilal,
Master of the Faith,

How do we find,
The path that is straight?”

“Ahadun ahad,
And you will succeed

Ahadun ahad,
Is all that you need.”

(Un)resolved

Anonymous

The ground shakes in fury
beneath her feet.

The ground is her witness.

Her footprints imprinted in

A moist mud and uprooted winter grass.

She steps towards a gate and the ground screams.

The ground suffers and stings.

I didn't know how the Earth spoke to her Lord before.

Once a children's tale,

a creed I couldn't comprehend.

I now bear witness

that the ground has always borne witness.

The ground cries, my heart cries.

My essence plummets.

My legs are listless in oceans.

My love walks away from me.

The moon and clouds hang over me, testifying.
Creations of a Lord with no need for them testifying.
Creator of a perfect system of testifying.
Revealer of the truth, Revealer of oppression.
Al-Zahir.

My brokenness has been mended by Al-Jabbar.
Forgetfulness and time move these matters to dull aches
Apologies were arranged and
her expansive heart welcomes me again.
People can only hold their breath for so long.

And yet, clay did not breathe before the Lord's breath.
The ground underneath me does not exhale
Only the Most Merciful restrains her from swallowing me whole.
She erupts under my feet and stares her daggers into my every step.
She is resentful
Of having to carry
Me.

The Highest Companionship

Hassaan Qadir

For you I would sell my entire dunya,
But the akhirah is worth even more,
There's nothing I desire more than your smile,
Except the pleasure of Allah,
When the blessed Prophet was in Aisha's lap,
He was given a choice,
Worldly bliss with his favorite wife,
Or companionship with the Most High,
He made his choice,
And so have I.

Woe

Anonymous

Woe to those who worship man!
He shall die
And so shall thy!
Submerged in Earth
That once was hallowed

To your eyes
Was it not shown?
What man had sowed?
Mountains of useless gold
Rivers of innocent blood

Now look again at the heavens!
Look again at the Earth!
Did man construct
Stars?
Oceans?
Or galaxies?
Or did man construct
Skyscrapers?
Weapons?
And falsehood?

So cherish the one who granted you sight
And filled the world with color
Would you ever exchange the chance to see
For a chance to be the richest man on Earth?



Blessed Olive Tree

Hassaan Qadir

The olive tree,
Scientific name,
Olea europaea,
Elia in Greek,
Olivae in Latin,
Zayith in Hebrew,
Zaytuna in Arabic.

The blessed olive tree,
Does it know,
in what language,
Its praise is sung?
How could it,
When it speaks,
No human tongue?

But it can feel,
The hands,
Nimble touch,
The olive farmer knows,
He must not be rough,
The oil will grow thick,
And make pouring tough.

Olives were first cultivated for oil,
Thousands of years before we
learned to eat them,
Homer's heroes,
And Roman emperors,
Would anoint themselves,
In olive oil,
And the early Jews,
Kept an olive oil flame,
Alive within the Temple,
In the Holy Quran,
God describes His Light,
Like that of a lamp,
Lit from the purest oil,
Of a blessed olive tree
Noor-un ala noor,
Light upon light.

The blessed olive tree,
Does it know,
upon whose face,
It casts its light?
How could it,
When it has,
No human sight?



But it can feel,
the hands,
Careful pruning,
Dead branches are removed,
For the health of the tree,
And the wood is prized,
As a rare beauty.

The Romans spoke of an olive
tree,
Providing shade to the whole
city,
And in the Old Testament,
The Prophet Noah received an
olive branch from God,
Signaling peace and friendship.

The blessed olive tree,
Does it know,
What its branches symbolize?
How could it,
When it has,
No human eyes?

But it can fell,
The hands,
Gentle pull.

Once we discovered olive
fermentation,
Various Mediterranean cultures,
Prized the olive as a food,
And in an act of charity,
When the harvest time came,
Families would leave some
olives on the tree,
So even the poor could eat,
In various cuisines,
The olive was found,
From the Hellens to the Hebrews,
The Spaniards to the Semites,
For thousands of years,
The olive connected all,
The fruit was in every dish,
The oil lit every lamp,
And all could sit under the shade
of a blessed olive tree,
For thousands of years,
Before the Lawrence and the
Kaiser,
Before Balfour and the Beer
Hall,
Before the UN and the Nakba.

The blessed olive tree,
Does it know,
The history?
It was there.

Bilal Saleh was 40 years old,
When he was killed,
But the trees he tended to,
Were much older.

The average olive tree,
Is 500 years old,
500 years ago,
1524,
Would have been just a few
years,
After the Ottoman Turks,
Took the Holy Lands,
From the Mamluk Egyptians,
Muslims fighting Muslims,
Unfortunately common.

But when they took control,
They set up systems of laws,
Millets,
Rabbinic law for the Jews,
Canon law for the Christians,
Shariah law for the Muslims,
And the Sultan's law,
Maintaining justice,
Between the three.

The blessed olive tree
Does it know,
Under whose law it grows?

Bilal Saleh was 40 years old,
When he was killed,
But the trees he tended to,
Were much older.

Olive groves are inherited,
Generation to generation,
Passed down as villages evolve,
And tribes migrate,
For thousands of years,
Muslims,
Christians,
And Jews,
Lived side-by-side,
In the Holy Lands,
Not in perfect harmony,
But a peaceful coexistence,
All worshipping the One God.

In the late 1800s,
As the Zionist movement,
Gained steam,
European settlers were shocked,
To find Jewish
And Muslim families,
Living in the very same buildings,
As they had done,
For years and years,
For 500 years,
Under the shade,
Of the blessed olive tree.

But 11 months ago,
Bilal Saleh was 40 years old,
When he was killed,
By illegal settlers,
Shot dead in front of his
children,
In the middle of the day,
As his family harvested olives,
From their very own trees.

Bilal Saleh was 40 years old,
When he was killed,
But the trees he loved,
Were much older.

And when the settler,
Burns down a tree,
To send a message,
To the Palestinians,
And when the IDF,
Clears a grove,
To build a road,
For those settlers,
Bilal Saleh,
May have been 40 years old,
The Israeli occupation,
May be 75 years old,
But the olive trees they kill,
Are much,
Much older,

Older than Haniyeh and
Netanyahu,
Older than Arafat and Sharon,
Older than Lawrence and Faisal,
Older than Herzl and Balfour.

The blessed olive tree,
Does it know,
The hate it takes?
How could it,
When it only gives love?

But it knows,
The hands which loved it,
And which yet return,
Sneaking past barbed wire and bullets,
To gather Palestinian seeds.

The blessed olive tree,
Like all blessings,
Is slow to cultivate,
Quick to quell,
But like the spirit,
Of all God's Noble Creation,
The olive tree,
Always grows back.

Bilal Saleh was 40 years old,
When he was killed,
But the children he loved,
Are still alive.



And with the seeds they save,
The blessed olive tree lives on,
Through 400 years of coexistence,
100 years of oppression,
A childhood with their father,
A lifetime without.

The IDF may bomb,
The settlers may burn,
But a handful of seeds,
Will always survive.

And 500 years from now,
The children of Bilal's children,
May walk amongst the olive
groves,
Planted during this war,
Planted during the beautiful moments,
of peace,
Moments,
scattered,
Like seeds in the sand.

The blessed olive tree,
Does it know,
What the future holds,
For it,
Or the Palestinians?
I think it does,
For it knows God,
And He watches over,
His Dominions.

The Rabbi and The Sound

Platon Rama

The Rabbi carried a small pen in his hand.
The small pen scribbled on an old scroll.
And because of that small pen, the Rabbi felt his fingers tire.

*“Governor of Palestine, I am Eliyahu son of Natan.
I know today the Byzantines war, but I ask for relief.
Last year’s earthquake took out our wells and a roof.”*

Surrounding the Rabbi was a Tower.
Around the Tower were the books of his people.
The books stared across centuries, and he could feel their weight.

*“This is my seventieth summer here. I have witnessed many changes.
But still, some things stay all the same.
That is why I write.”*



It was raining now.
The chickens stopped their pecking.
They hushed for the drops rattling the Tower.

*“Each year that passes the less return to the valley.
The young and married go to the cities.
We are an ancient community.”*

A strange sound!
At his chin, the Rabbi let the small pen down.
And because he rested the small pen, the Rabbi got up from his injured table.

The Rabbi moved around the first floor to find the sound.
With each corner checked, legacy piled on his dusting fingers.
But when he found no sound, he returned to his table.

*“Your Excellency, our valley shrinks.
The tax collectors come twice before the harvest.
We cannot stay.”*

The *sound* again!
Scratching his head, the Rabbi got up from where he stood.
And because he stood, the Rabbi set a wooden ladder
and climbed a second story.

Here, he lit a candle.
The window was shaded by a curtain.
The Rabbi found old friends in the tales that surrounded him there.

Looking past and to some boxes, the Rabbi learned only webs.
Still no source did he find in that burning candle light.
It burned bright with a thousand year old hope.

An aging back, the Rabbi sighed.
There was nothing to find.
And because there was nothing, he returned to the table.

*"This is not my first time asking for help.
The problems switch but our needs remain.
I will keep asking."*

A third time! At once the Rabbi rose.
The scroll in his hand, the Rabbi gathered a way up the Tower.
Hasty, he forgot his small pen.

The stairs creaked with each step.
The Rabbi paused to sigh, running his fingers through seventy years of
living.
At last he arrived at the top where there was no roof.

The skies had mostly cleared.
An orange view, it gave way to pink and red.
The man breathed. Clouds still clung to the eastern edges.

His eyes gazed toward Zion, to the horizon.
The black hills were alive with a tapping sound.
The Rabbi could make out the bobbing dots of men.

It was the marching noise of a thousand men or more.
They carried black banners, horses beside them.
At once jubilant, the Rabbi's face reflected a smiling sigh.

From the sunlight the Rabbi hurried.
Down the tower, down the stairs, he retrieved his small pen.
Back at the table, he started a new scroll.

*"Army of the Muslims, I am Eliyahu son of Natan.
Indeed, God's help does come through many hands.
The river is near. Jerusalem is near.*

*"This is my seventieth summer. I have witnessed many changes.
But still, some things stay all the same.
That is why I write."*

*And so the Muslims would go on to win this war.
People of the Book, they lived together near Jerusalem for 460 years until the Crusades.
And after that, another 730 years.*

The End.

I'm in the Old City When I See Her

Hassaan Qadir

The midday sun bores down
On those old sandstone walls
And the cats slink to the shade
Sleek with their fur
And I've just finished my lunch
And sit down with a sigh

But out the corner my eye
I see her walk by
A light-green abaya
Like myrtle in desert
What's in her hands?
Now I'm looking at her
She's staring at me
And I see her smile
Those dark eyes meet mine
And stay for a while
Her flowing hijab
shimmers like mirage
And she speaks in the tongue
That all Muslims love

But I'm too in love
To make out a word
She gestures to follow
And steps with a twirl
I'm off my chair

As she rounds the corner
There's heat in the air,
Too much for a foreigner,
I ask for her name,
Best as I can say,
She laughs and continues,
Further down the way,
Right into a souk,
With burning incenses,
I close my eyes,
And pause for the senses.
Little steps pattering down the
cobblestone.
A ball bouncing between the
walls.
Bounce, bounce, bounce.
Ya Ahmed! Hadha! Hadha!

The sound of children laughing.
A big kick and thwap! The ball
hits my head.
I open my eyes,
All in a daze,
The kids have gone quiet,
They're all afraid,
I pick up the ball,
And survey the scene,

Tweens and toddlers,
and in-between,
Their cute faces watching,
The short ones might cry,
The ball in my hand,
A glint in my eye,

Turedu? Ta'al!

I dribble the ball,
And kick off the wall,
The kids start to cheer,
They're laughing again,
I pass to a boy,
He passes it back,
The sounds of our game,
Echo through the halls,
With men coming back,
To open their stalls,

"I should probably stop acting
like a kid,"

I think to myself,
"Attracting attention,
Might bring me some trouble."

"Trouble comes either way,
So we should be kind,
Play with the kids,
And give them your time"

Right by my side,
She's somehow appeared,
A smile so wide,
My worries are cleared.

"So you speak English?
Is this where you were taking
me?"

She laughs with her eyes,
And exits the souk,
Walking through the gate,
And I follow suit,
She glides up the stairs,
The laughter recedes,
She knocks on a door,
At the edge of the street,

A man opens up,
Hugs her as his daughter,
Sees me with a frown,
Asks her why I'm here,

"We met in the market,"
(Not entirely false),
"He's looking for heirlooms,"
(And I'll play along),

"Salam ya uncle,
Those guys tried to scam me,
Your daughter saved me,
She's from a good family,

I'm looking for something,
To take to my home,
Inlaid with silver,
Or plated with gold,"

"Ah yes, I can tell,
That you have good taste,
And now you have come,
To the perfect place."
He draws me inside,
To his little store,
Shows me his wares,
And says there is more,

We chat and relax,
As Arabs do,
His daughter returns,
With tea cups for two,

Her glance is averted,
So shy and restrained,
But under the surface,
Her smile hasn't waned,

I sit with her father,
We discuss the news,
The prices of land,
And life with the Jews,

The old father tells me,
He has just the thing,
A token to buy,
That's fit for a king,

He pulls out a box,
Of plain cedarwood,
Opens it up,
And pulls out a sword,

Blade shining bright,
The hilt is inscribed,
Quranic verses,
Catching my eye,

The daughter now joins,
We all sit and talk,
Shake hands with the father,
A bargain is struck,

A beautiful day,
It's time for salat,
But before we can pray,
There's a heavy knock,

A knock...
and a knock...

A shout and a crash,
The door off its hinge,
A bang and a flash,
The smoke starts to singe,

“Dit kufef!”
“Subhanallah!”
Foo foo foo!
Krooh!
Aah!

The soldiers rush in,
tearing up the room,
The father is shouting,
The daughter is gone,
All of a sudden, I’m grabbed,
And thrown out the door,
“Get up!” they shout,
A gun in my face,
The world is still spinning,
Ears ringing, I’m dazed,

I’m grabbed by my shirt,
My hands on the walls,
Can’t speak a word,
Can’t open my jaws,
The ring in my ears,
Was deafening loud,
It’s quieting now,
All quiet around,
As he pats me down,

I look at the ground,
It’s hotter than ever,
But there is no sound,

From inside the store,
What’s happening there?
As he lets me go,
I can’t help but stare,
The building has changed,
There’s pain in the air,

The windows are barred,
The flowers are gone,
They’re cameras now,
With fencing around,

Tiles once vivid,
Now dusty and gray,
Echoes of laughter,
Have all slipped away,

The door with its handle,
That she used to knock,
Is now chained shut,
With thick iron lock,
Against this backdrop,
An Israeli flag,
Perched at the top,
The heat makes it sag,

In horror, I lurch,
and stumble away,
Seeking out answers,
unsure what to say.
Around the corner,
an old man appears,
"Salam, ya uncle,
Who lives over there?"

"It used to be Arab,
now it's not theirs,
Zionists took it,
amid many prayers.
It happened of course,
by Israel's hand,
They claimed the deed false,
the state took the land."

"When did this happen?"
I ask with a frown,
"A few years ago,
the family left town."
A few years ago?
I ponder, perplexed,
What did I witness?
My mind feels so vexed.

My head is throbbing,
My eyes are so dry,
I sit and close them,
And breathe for a while,

And as I sit down the street,
from the Zionist occupation,
The familiar noise of the Old
City returns,
The sounds filter to my station,

And the spices waft by,
Floating up to the cameras,
And the children play free,
Running right by the soldiers,
And under the oppressive heat,
This city keeps breathing,

And as I lift my head,
I see her walk by,
Sadness in her eyes,
But still there's a smile

Self-Determination

Hasaan Qadir

My grandma was ten years old when they took her,
Kicked in the door in the middle of the night,
She never saw her mother again,
She dressed like a boy and went with her father,

That's the only reason she survived,
She used to tell me over shabbat,
A roll of the dice between her and death,
But now we have our own state to keep us safe,

And I always thought our state would keep us safe,
But just over a year ago,
Everything changed,
Because really nothing had changed,

And when I saw the pictures,
And the videos from the south,
When I saw the burnt cars,
And women holding their kids,

I was mad that the world let this happen again,
How could the state let this happen again?
Ashamed that I let this happen again,
I couldn't look grandma in the eye.

So me and my friends all enlisted,
And I remember my first day inside the walls,
We'd called in a strike on a nest,
And had to take care of the rest,

My eyes watered from the dust,
My tongue was dry from the heat,
The school was just rubble,
Concrete and glass,

Twisted rebar and burst pipes,
Dogs fighting over scraps of —,
I saw an arm sticking out from the dirt,
I pulled out a kid with a hole in his chest,

He opened his mouth as if to scream,
And I wish he had made a sound,
I wish he had made a sound,
I wish he had screamed,

But blood spurted out,
And it gushed and it gushed,
And he bled and he bled till it emptied him out,
And he couldn't have been more than ten.

What Happens to Innocence

Anonymous

They say,
our innocence dwells only in the womb—

that it lingers in the blush of stork bites,
in lifeblood humming beneath paper skin,
in the breath of angels—
still warm upon a mother,
crushed beneath the rubble,
who will not rise again.

And they say,
once we breathe, we betray it—
that the first breath tastes of iron,
our lips chapped, yet wet with a stain
they will not let us swallow.
So they press silence between them,
smother our cry before it's born.

But I heard a voice—
my mother's,
departing the earth,
climbing the rubble:
"There is no god but God."

Her breath became mine,
and our voices sank together
beneath ceilings of stone,
then of one,
until fire found us
and carved our names into the smoke.
I searched for innocence
in the ruins—
between walls hemmed with wires,
in maternity wards turned to ash,
among nurturing arms of the dead
that swaddle only absence.

I searched for water
in broken glass—
cupped my hands
and drank the salt of the sea,
where children float in its froth
with no names
and no graves.

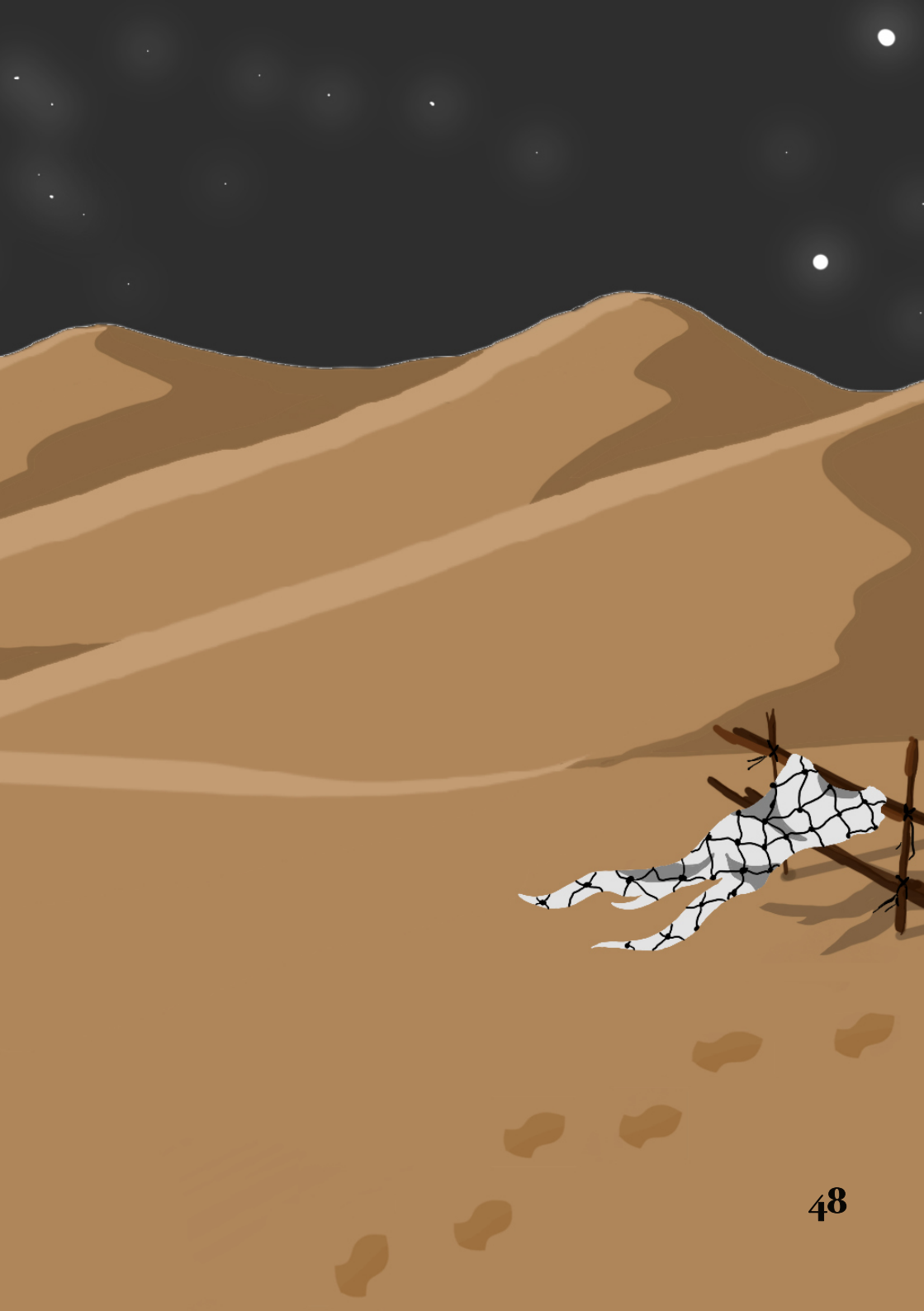
Still,
the sky tore open,
bright wings breaking the dark.
Feathers brushed her brow
like remembrance,
and the earth loosened its hold.
Her body slackened,
and gravity itself forgot her name.

But those who fenced the horizon,
and called it theirs,
who stripped the olive branch
bare of its peace,
they cast me into the well,
nameless,

as though a child without a name
were only reflection on water,
weightless,
trembling at the first ripple.

Even there,
in the hush of the well,
stones drop faster than our cries,
as if to bury the womb itself.

And I wonder
what happens to innocence
when the world crushes the wombs
that were once made to bear it.



Oh Saharan plague and acacia bark,
Do your orange irises beguile me

Sharp, crimson, and pure

As pupils lined with kohl

The wind today tells me you are near
You're always near, the stain of iron.

Oh Saharan plague and acacia bark,
Yesterday I sang to the moon

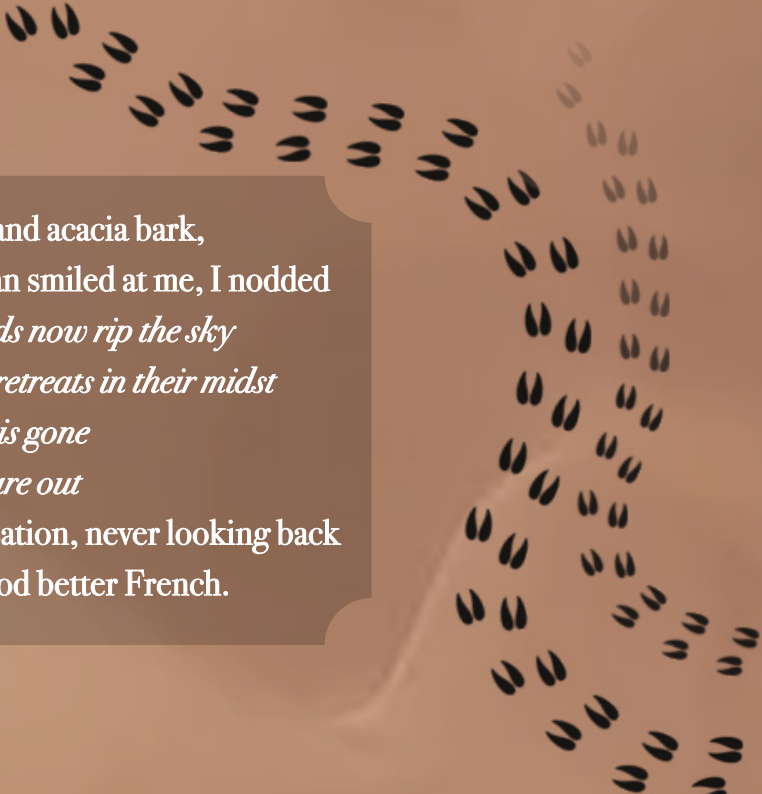
I stood the dunes

That killed the martyr

Withstanding plumes

With sand in my eyes

Her phases, my most bitter enemy
Last night she was a friend.



Oh Saharan plague and acacia bark,
Today a Bedouin man smiled at me, I nodded
Fleshed clouds now rip the sky
And the sun retreats in their midst
The warmth is gone
The jackals are out
We headed to civilization, never looking back
The camel understood better French.

Oh Saharan plague and acacia bark,
I found an injured antelope
His mother's head lay by the well
Each tear plucking the water surface
Rolling over stones
Rounding the edges
I cried for the calf, for the mother,
And the difference between them.



Along the Avenue

Ramy Triki

With a single tip of his glass, Habib Bourguiba shattered centuries of tradition. In the blistering heat of Ramadan, he stood in the city square as if on a stage, his presence commanding an ominous silence. Slowly, almost ceremonially, he raised the glass to his lips, letting the sunlight catch on its rim, casting tiny refracted spears of light across the crowd. Bourguiba's gaze swept over them, steady and unflinching, daring anyone to challenge him. And then he drank—a quiet rebellion swallowed in one sip. In a single act, an unflinching declaration that he and his country would not be bound by the shackles of the past. Such was Habib Bourguiba, the man brave enough to challenge God himself.

Over sixty years later, as I walked through the avenue in Tunisia that now bears his name, Bourghiba's presence still lingered. Glass storefronts rose on either side, their pristine facades a studied echo of the Champs-Élysées. Tunisians in jeans and sleek Western attire filled the streets as neon signs pulsed overhead, casting the pavement in splintered light. The avenue felt like a mirror facing Paris, but the reflection was distorted, roughened at the edges. Palm trees swayed along the sidewalks, threading together modernist architecture with the enduring stone of Islamic tradition. I walked as if pulled by some quiet force, pulling together fragments of history that, like the avenue, twisted under the weight of time. Here and there, an old man leaned against the faded stone, watching, maybe remembering Bourguiba himself, the man, the myth, the vision that wouldn't let go.

Further ahead, a large bronze figure loomed, casting an unmistakable silhouette: Bourguiba sitting on horseback, his hand raised in a gesture part way between command and blessing. The statue seemed out of place amid the avenue's polish, yet it was this very outstretching of his hand that embodied the ambition that once blazed through these streets. His eyes looked ahead, fixed on a distant point somewhere past the horizon, a place only he could see. The statue seemed frozen in anticipation, as if Bourguiba himself was still urging the country forward. His horse reared, locked in mid-gallop, caught between stillness and the motion he so craved.

Bourguiba's crisp black suit and polished leather shoes were the clothes of modernity, but it was his Chechia hat—small, round, and distinctly Tunisian—that tethered him to his roots, a reminder of the country he had promised to uplift. It was the same hat in which, as a young law student, he would often walk along this very avenue with his mentor, Tahar Haddad, discussing the inequalities and injustices of colonialism, burning with revolutionary fervor. It was the same hat he wore while imprisoned by the French for 11 years, slouched in a crowded jail cell, scrawling clandestine notes on paper napkins while World War II raged outside. The same hat he wore as he stood atop the podium at the city hall, celebrating his country's long-awaited independence as its first president.

Standing at the statue's base, I could feel the energy Bourguiba once possessed as a leader, the will to mold a nation to his vision. As president, Bourguiba's freedom went beyond the political; it was a departure from customs and symbols he deemed shackles. Even now, his bronze hand seemed to reject the grip of history, a hand that drank openly during Ramadan, a hand that tore through centuries-old expectations. Bourguiba saw himself as both liberator and reformer, a figure blazing a modern path through the thicket of tradition. To him, Islam was like the walls of a medina: beautiful, but confining. To let in progress, he had to open the gates. He fought the hijab, allowed women into schools and parliament seats, and outlawed polygamy, each act chipping against the granite of the past. But there is a line between a chisel and hammer, between the sculptor and the wrecking ball. Bourguiba never saw that line.

My aunts were among the first women in Tunisia to attend university (then an unheard-of opportunity in the Arab world). In old black-and-white photos, you can see them smiling, books held close to their chest, as they stood in the courtyard of a college that now finally belonged to them, too. It was Bourguiba's hand that opened those doors, that allowed them to believe that maybe, just maybe, this was their freedom too.

But as I circled the statue, I began to notice small cracks along Bourguiba's raised arm, tiny fractures that seemed to question his once unyielding grip on power. The metal strained against itself, a statue weighted by its own contradictions. Here, in the January 14th square—a space commemorating Tunisia's independence and self-rule—the remnants of French culture still filled the air like lingering smoke. Conversations spilled from cafés, blending Arabic and French, mingling with the aroma of fresh croissants and carefully baked tarts. Renaults and Peugeot's sputtered down the road, their exhaust curling in the sunlight, shading the avenue in a thin veil. Glass storefronts caught the light and reflected it back like fractured mirrors, each glint an echo of European elegance, a reminder of a legacy Bourguiba couldn't completely erase, or maybe didn't want to.

Even his outstretched hand, once a symbol of liberation, now looked rusted, tainted by the slow, corrosive drip of time and power. What had once beckoned Tunisia toward freedom seemed now to claw at it, fingers curling inward, wrapped around the very chains he had once vowed to sever. For Bourguiba, it was never enough; it was freedom, but under his rules. In the name of progress, unions fell silent, their voices stifled by mandates from above; in the name of unity, political dissenters were swept away into shadowed cells. Bourguiba, the "Supreme Combatant" who once braved imprisonment for the nation's liberation, crowned himself "President for Life."

I slowly stepped away from the statue and continued walking. The avenue stretched ahead, and as I came near its end, I could hear a murmur, the whisper of the past that refused to be silenced. From somewhere beyond the trees and tall buildings, the adhan swelled over the rooftops, rolling through the streets and drawing men in white robes toward the mosques. Closer to the border of the avenue, the smoke of hookah, thick and sweet, carried in, mingling near small restaurants with the aroma of couscous, lamb, and mloukhia, portals to a world old and rich, still humming beneath the layers Bourguiba tried to peel away. Even here, on this avenue mimicking Paris's stone and glass, the city clung to its dust and sand, the soil it came from, the desert that lingered beneath every building, every boulevard.

At the edge of the avenue, on the corner of El Mourouj Street, the Café de Paris stood as it had for decades. Its rusted metal chairs sat neatly under bright blue umbrellas, shading patrons from the relentless sun. On warm afternoons, Bourguiba would walk down from his palace to sit here among the locals, waving off his bodyguards. With his Chechia tilted rakishly, he sipped cappuccinos for hours, his hands gesturing to match the pace of his words, as he debated the hot topics of the day. For all his flaws, Bourguiba carried an undeniable charm, a magnetism that could still mesmerize even as the edges of his image began to unravel.

The avenue quietly emptied into winding streets, eventually pulling me into the district of Sidi Bousaid. It was a historic district, dotted by the old white and blue houses of the Ottomans, overlooking a coastline flecked with turquoise waves and white sails. European families scattered along the beach, lounging in sun chairs under linen parasols, children sprinting barefoot toward the water. And high above, perched on the edge of the cliff like a sentinel, stood the President's house, the palace Bourguiba claimed for his own—a pristine white villa, elegant but solid, timeless. Standing on that hill, looking back at the city, I wondered if Bourguiba saw his reign the same way. The palace, tucked between the Mediterranean waves and the dust of Tunisia, felt like a world apart from the city below. I could imagine Bourghiba sitting on the patio with his wife Mathilda, a president and his first lady, at the crossroads of her French heritage and his Tunisian roots, watching over the country.

It seems fitting that it was here, only streets away, that a fruit vendor lit himself aflame in 2011, sparking the Arab Spring, a fire of its own that roared through Tunisia, through Egypt, Syria, Libya, searing away old regimes. In a violent succession, the citizens of the Arab world gathered and revolted against their oppressors from within, casting off the shadows of Bourguiba and his successors.

Bourguiba himself had been forced to relinquish power long before, in 1987. After three long decades in power, age and autocracy had eroded his body and spirit, leaving only a fragile husk. A team of doctors, led by the general Zine Ben-Ali, deemed Bourguiba physically unfit to rule, and confined him to a quiet life in his hometown of Monastir. There, the streets he had once filled with his booming voice and fiery proclamations now passed him by in silence. The restless energy that had driven him to walk among crowds, captivating them with every gesture, was now stilled, his speeches replaced by the muted shuffle of an old man pacing an empty courtyard. After seizing power, Ben-Ali worked to erase Bourguiba's presence from Tunisian streets, dismantling statues of his predecessor across the country as if to sand away the memory of his rule. But by 2016, only five years after Ben-Ali's deposition, the city of Monastir resurrected its statue of Bourguiba, defying the effort to erase him. His bronze face emerged once again, defiant even in immobility, refusing to bow even to time. Some grumbled that Bourguiba belonged to a past best left buried, his legacy a thing too fractured and fraught to celebrate. But others looked up at his visage with something like reverence, recalling a time when Tunisia's path seemed carved in stone, when it stood proud as a leader of the Arab world, before its dreams had soured.

As dusk seeped into the streets and lights began to flicker to life, I headed back through the avenue. In the fading light, Bourguiba's face seemed to deepen in shadow, his jawline chiseled but softened, his gaze still fixed on that vision of the future. The streets around me pulsed with the movement of shoppers, but there, in that quiet corner of Tunis, his shadow lingered, the silent weight of choices cast in bronze, still daring his country forward, even now, to keep pace with him or fall away.

The Oil Was Already Hot

Ramy Triki

The oil was already hot
when I arrived –
that kind of heat that hums
before it burns.

At my grandmother's house,
the table was always too small.
A bowl of dough rested
rising with a patience I didn't possess.
She fried because I loved them.
That was the recipe.

I watched from the doorway,
waiting,
as the dough surrendered:
rose, blistered,
turning the color of late afternoon.
Sugar afterward, always sugar.
I learned sweetness before language.

Years passed.
The house learned silence.
The oil cooled.

*

This year, my roommate said,
You should make them.
As if memory were something
you could knead back into shape.

Before I knew it,
flour was on the counter,
on my shirt,
on my mother's hands.
She didn't measure.
She never has.

I stood beside her,
frying something
for the first time
I could remember.
The oil spoke again.

*

My brother hovered close.
His eyes widened
at the same moment mine once had,
In awe
of the miracle of dipping
fried dough into pure sugar,
the way joy announces itself
without asking permission.

I saw myself there,
waiting.

*

Later, at someone else's table,
a different grandmother worked.
Palaçinka folded thin as breath.
Sheqerpare cracked open,
sweet spilling out
like a secret that wanted telling.

No one explained anything.
No one had to.

*

We eat what survives.
What is passed hand to hand
when words fail.
What remembers us
when we forget ourselves.

The oil keeps going.
The sugar waits.
Someone is always watching
from the doorway.

Vacation in Tirana

Platon Rama

The bushes were burning? I only had a few seconds before we passed them, but I saw the shrubs on fire. By this point, my father had been driving in the Albanian summer heat for what felt like two hours. The sky was blue with a cheering bright hue that was starting to nudge me toward a tolerance of the rental car's excessive tightness. And yet, there were patches of fire flanking the highway and I did not know why.

"Do not worry. It's not a big deal." My dad tiredly assured me. For no fault of his own, I did not feel reassured.

Afterall, it was 2023 and we had just escaped North America (which was still coughing under the saffron sky of Canada's wildfires) and it was a hot season down here in Albania. I had heard of nearby fires in Greece getting out of control and felt selfishly worried about my accountability in the affair. What if the fire got out of hand? Would God blame me for not stopping it with a simple phone call? My brother delivered a hesitant glance at this point, his heavy eyebrows wrapped into a familiar position with the rest of his scrunched face. I was unsure this time whether he was still judging the trip's necessity or if his expression was directed at me.

Turns out it was just the farmers. Eventually, my suburban dwelling self put it together that controlled fires were normal and that God, I hope, was not going to judge me for failing to call Albania's version of 9-1-1.

It was quiet now on the road. Almost peaceful—particularly when compared to the arguments our little rental car had witnessed only a few days earlier. On this trip, I was resigned to being the black sheep of the family. I made us targets of supposed backbiting and unwanted attention my dad often begged, in the way I strapped my beard, adjusted my clothing, and approached others—all in accordance with Islam. In these conversations he would levy the input of my similarly minded brother, and I hated that.

Being Muslim back in New York was easy enough, but apparently returning to a place where you are no longer the minority was somehow more shameful. We disputed whether I should be returning as an Albanian rooted in his heritage. The road continued with surrounding infrastructure developing into view.

The mood in our car cooled (in contrast with the heat outdoors). Leaving a tight block had unsheathed our car from the squeezing folds of the tall buildings. Squinting—with light pouring through my window—I tipped my head toward my dad, and asked: “Are we there yet?”

“One second—the turns here are a mess.” My father controlled the car.

Accompanying his voice was the sound of a city jogging around us. It was an active day in Tirana, beeping with lights and pedestrians alike, far from the calmness of the beaches we’d been driving away from since this morning.

“You know, your uncle actually studied here for a bit,” my dad said.

“Oh? I didn’t know about that. That’s surprising.” My voice returned.

“Yes, he traveled up and down these streets often.”

I was genuinely surprised. I hadn’t been aware that the politics of the 1990s would have afforded my uncle a chance to study in Albania’s capital. Though he was Albanian himself, I knew his documents saddled him with a Macedonian residency—a place rooted in tension with Albania. I was also surprised because college students don’t usually end up as construction workers.

Our little rental car zoomed forward, up the winding paths and cobblestone streets, by the shops of Albanian grandmas, and past dirtied cement walls. I could see the city behind me now, and could distinguish one rooftop from another. We were getting higher, and closer to our destination.

“Here we are!” my dad exclaimed, as he negotiated the vehicle into the thin lot of a warm asphalt road. We all popped our doors and unloaded our sneakers from the car. I pulled our luggage to what I assumed was the hotel for tonight. There was a rectangle sliced into the wall, with a sign above it reading “reception” in three languages. Next to the hole, I found a line of people—really more of a crowd. We stood by a table.

This again?” my elder brother groaned.

“Patience my friend, it’ll serve ya,” I replied, with some bite.

He could not tolerate the old couple checking in slowly. I, with my expert diplomacy, continued extolling the virtues of patience and endurance. I added that such joys could only be tasted through discipline in liminal locations and experiences like these.

After a quick update from my father, however, my fidelity to such patience (and to this particular building) took an immediate hit. What I assumed was our hotel turned out to merely be a cable car station that we would use to travel to our lodgings, nestled deep in the mountains. We collected our tickets.

“No way I’m getting on a metal box 200 feet above the ground,” I said.

“Come along Pati,” my brother teased. “Remember, being patient is a virtue.”

“It’ll be fun,” my dad added. “It’s for the experience. Once in a lifetime.” His accent returned.

“No,” I hesitated, starting to walk with them. “It will be scary.”

We climbed up the wide, gray-yellow stairs. Forgetting the cable car, I didn’t even trust that this stairway could maintain our collective weight.

The second floor greeted us with glass and an open room with a wall intentionally missing, inviting a view of nature that stretched out far and uninterrupted. All that now separated us from the comfortable solid floor and the clean, terrifying air was a small collection of five tourist groups.

My father, with his sweating face, grinned with anticipation for our next ride. My brother and I each frowned in likewise disappointment.

“You scared?” I asked my brother.

“Me? No, I’m not scared.”

“How?”

“Well, I’ve just accepted that I can die. Nothing to be sad about”

“Quit kidding.”

“No actually, I’m serious.”

“Whatever.”

I was anxious. My brother always insists he is not nervous when he’s clearly nervous. I could tell. It was in the way he held the railings: his chest ahead of his shoulders and his hands behind his back. The way he stretched his neck and rolled his jaw.

My father turned to us, “You guys, it’s almost here,” he said, his eyes set on the cart. “Are you boys excited?”

“Maybe,” I said. My brother didn’t respond at the moment.

My father replied, “Come on, don’t joke.” His head swiveled back to the cart, “we came all the way here to see our country. To be together.”

“Alright, I’m excited,” I said, hugging my dad.

After the last packet of people leapt from the station, our cart came, elbowing around the track.

We grabbed our packages. I swept myself to one side of the cart, feeling it swing. My brother and father joined right after, sitting across from me while my legs guarded the baggage. We turned around slowly, ascending. My face looked back at the city skyline, my counterparts looking past me to the green mountain cliffs behind. My fear of capsizing stabilized with the cart.

My brother's eyes darted to the warning label haloing above the supposedly locked doors. His focused eyebrows revealed a doubt about our total weight, and whether it respected the limit depicted in kilograms. For his part, he never trusted Balkan facilities or their capacity, whether it be in Albania or Macedonia.

My dad breathed heavily. His forehead now glistened with the warmed sweat of a summer's headache. He tried finding solace in planning the camera app on his phone.

"Are you okay babi?"

"Yes," my dad sighed. "I'm just tired from driving. And the heat. That's all."

From what I could gather, my father was disappointed with this vacation so far. The constant complaining from his two sons tired him. Questioning himself, I imagine him regretting plotting a trip he knows will forecast ungrateful complaints. His head rested on the glass of the cart but he still remained worried about the comfort of his kids. He turned his face to me, "Stop being scared Pati. It's safe, look down."

I unlocked my gaze, staring elsewhere from the sky or the floor. I looked down, beyond my seat. We were higher than I expected, and though the cable car's shadow was shrinking rapidly, I could still make out the details of the land below. I saw the potted roofs of village homes, twined together with the unharvested roots of moss and vine. I noticed the roads stretching from houses increasingly padded with dirt as we strayed farther from the capital. Birds were flapping through the air, and I again saw the city behind them.

The higher the cable car trailed along the mountain, the more the country's age revealed itself. Bunkers from Enver Hoxha's four decades of reigning communism popped into view between the tree lines. What resembled unmarked pimples in the earth were likely the offspring of earlier artillery, dating from wars before Hoxha. Brown, dark rotten buildings—no longer distinguishable as either homes, mills, or pens—floated under us as I reviewed a flock of sheep dispersed across the field.

Between these reminders of Albania's past, intense streams of nature flourished. The cliffs seemed to grow braver as we soared higher. Gone were the reminders of buildings or farms; only lakes, trees, and flowers remained. On the horizon lay the jagged purple of Tirana, kissing the sinking golden air. It was beautiful.

The cart slowed again; the incline steadied. At my back was the cable car's destination, with a glass building behind it. The doors released, and my brother sighed. Our feet shuffled out of the cable car.

My brother and I happily removed our luggage from the cart, eager to process into the hotel in front of us. My father thanked the operator at the railing and pointed both of us toward the exit.

My father smiled and looked back down the line of the cable. I'd like to think he was imagining some sort of hike he could perform if he had all the time in the world—and not instead about the unfortunate attitudes of his two boys. From up here the roads looked thin, the houses small, and the fires we passed earlier were certainly invisible now. Whatever had been burning down there was no longer ours to manage. My dad wiped his forehead and stretched his back, already lighter.

"Come," he said.

And this time, I followed without arguing.

Epilogue of Islam

Hasaan Qadir

I've been reading a lot recently about historical practices of the shariah and Islamic civilization, and it can be saddening to see how it's all fallen. I recently visited Athens, and all that remains of the Ottoman Mosque atop the Acropolis—like countless others across Iberia, the Balkans, Palestine, the Steppe, and India—are faint sketches and passing mentions in poorly-translated manuscripts.

The wise, pragmatic, divinely-inspired legal system that governed millions from Cordoba to Kuala Lumpur, maintaining predictability, stability, and justice for centuries even as dynasties rose and fell, has been torn to shreds. Laws of commerce and gender relations that once preserved societies are now dismissed as relics of a bygone age. Even a clear understanding of our history and way of life feels locked behind poor translations, pillaged libraries, and masterpieces lost to time. And so, even as we know Islam is eternal, we may sometimes feel dislocated from our true time period—like castaways floating on a life raft, making do with what little could be saved from the great ship of the Caliphate.

But I recently heard an Imam remind us that this is all part of Allah's Plan. When He designed this final Ummah, this Ummah Wasat—the middle, primary, best nation—He prepared us for these very times. He foresaw the rise of atheistic rationalism, so He sent the most rationally supported Prophet. He foresaw the collapse of sexual ethics, so He gave us the firmest and most sustaining laws of chastity. He foresaw the supremacy of legal positivism, so He gave us the most decentralized yet unified jurisprudence.

Today, when the world holds more Muslims than ever before, we realize that the story of Islam has not dwindled into a footnote of history—it has swelled into its greatest chapter. More Muslims have lived after 1800 than before it. This means the challenges and opportunities of modernity are not an afterword to Islam’s story, but the very stage Allah prepared for us.

Just as thousands of Prophets culminated in Prophet Muhammad, countless generations of Muslims have culminated in us. And when the Day of Judgement arrives, and the Prophet looks upon his Ummah (and we make dua to be counted among them), he will not see us as stragglers washed ashore from a lost age, but as the vast bulk of his community—the ones he wept for, prayed for, and longed to meet. We are not the afterword of the Islamic story; we are its living chapter. We are not the epilogue; we are the main act.

The End

Closing Reflections

So here we are.

Perhaps you picked up this issue because a friend was featured. Perhaps you saw an announcement and grew curious. Perhaps you are not Muslim, but simply wanted to understand what our corner of the world looks like. Whatever brought you here, we are grateful you chose to spend your time with us.

Thank you, truly. This publication exists because writers were brave enough to share their work and readers were generous enough to receive it. We hope these pages offered reflection, inspiration, and maybe even a new way of seeing.

But this is not the end. The conversations within this issue—about family, faith, justice, purpose, and action—are meant to continue beyond it. If a line lingered with you, follow it. If an idea stirred something in you, explore it. If a poem has been waiting quietly in your notes, write it. Legacy grows when we participate in it!

And this is only the beginning. ILM is both a magazine and a community, and we look forward to future issues, gatherings, and conversations. We hope you will join us—as readers, as writers, and as part of what comes next.

Until then, you are loved, you are bright, you are awesome. Keep writing.

With gratitude,
The ILM Editorial Team

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And I wonder

What happens to innocence

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With a single tip of his glass, Habib
Bourguiba shattered centuries of
tradition.

page 52

For you I would sell my entire dunya,
But the akhirah is worth even more,

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